No final-month surge for Republicans in view

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This week in polling: No final-month surge for Republicans in view. The national picture was largely unchanged this week: Democrats maintained their n||||||||||||||||

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This week in polling: No final-month surge for Republicans in view. The national picture was largely unchanged this week: Democrats maintained their nine-point lead in the generic congressional ballot, and President Trump’s approval rating stayed below 38%.

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There is no sign yet of any surge for Republicans in the final weeks of the race that would let them stem their losses in the House and retain control of the Senate. With gas prices still high and September inflation numbers coming in hot, the causes of today’s strongly Democratic-leaning national environment are structural, and there’s little Trump or national Republicans can do in the next two weeks to change that.
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Across the board, the likely decisive Senate races remained close, with a slight lean toward Democrats this week. Democrats and Republicans traded off leads in Iowa, Kansas, and Texas. Maine and Ohio look to be moving slightly towards Democrats: Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) hasn’t led in a Maine poll since late September, and Sherrod Brown has had six-point leads in the last two polls in Ohio.
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The Democratic underbelly still looks somewhat soft. In Michigan, Democrat Abdul El-Sayed hasn’t trailed in a single poll in the last month, but there are some signs the race is narrowing; every October poll has had him up by only one or two points. It’s much the same in Minnesota, where Democrat Peggy Flanagan hasn’t led by more than four points. If polls are overstating Democratic strength specifically in the Upper Midwest, like in recent presidential elections, these races could easily go to Republicans.

How Republicans could still keep the Senate. While we see Democrats as the moderate favorites to flip the Senate (60%), it’s worth thinking about what it would take for Republicans to retain the majority

(40% odds).

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For the most part, it's a simple answer. Across the Senate races, the polling is close enough that a regular-sized national polling error of around three or four points, against Democrats, would suffice for Republicans to sweep essentially every competitive race, including Michigan. That would leave Senate control unchanged, at 53-47. (Democrats would still pick up North Carolina in this scenario.)

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This scenario would look similar to what happened to Republicans in 2022: they experienced a six-point national swing from the 2020 election, but fell just barely short of a majority with slim losses in Nevada and Georgia.

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The fact that the polling slightly favors Democrats in almost every state, however, also means that a larger majority of 55 seats is in play if polling is understating Democratic support.

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The other possibility is simple mean reversion. Democrats have been riding a high in the competitive Senate races for weeks now, with their candidates' polling outperforming the partisan baseline in every Republican-held seat except Maine, even accounting for the national swing. It wouldn't be surprising to see that high come to an end, and for states to revert slightly to their partisan baseline; indeed, that appears to be happening in Maine in recent weeks (albeit in Democrats' direction).

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This scenario wouldn't see a polling miss—rather, polls would move by a few points toward Republicans in the closing days of the campaign—but it would have the same implications: Democrats would fall just barely short in most states.

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For the reasons outlined in our last Senate update (see Polling gains boost Democratic odds in House and Senate , 6 October 2026), we don't think either of these scenarios is likely, and assess that Democratic leads in the competitive states give them enough cushion against state-specific polling errors. But it wouldn't take much for Republicans to hold on, just barely.

Hormuz attacks likely to drive US escalation after midterms. An escalation of the conflict in which the US resumes kinetic strikes against Iran after the midterms is likely (65%, up from 35%), as US efforts to move oil through the Strait of Hormuz falter amid Iranian attacks.

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While the US "wait and see" approach, using economic pressure to force Iranian concessions, was sustainable when oil flows were rising, its viability has deteriorated as Iranian attacks on shipping continue and energy prices remain stubbornly elevated.

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The US has various military options, ranging from large-scale bombing raids to more limited strikes against targets near the strait; there will be three carrier strike groups in the region by early November, giving the US significant offensive and defensive firepower. Any resumption of strikes is likely to trigger Iranian retaliation and move oil prices into a higher range of $110-$125 per barrel.

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New strikes are unlikely to force more concessions from Iran, while the need to improve the unsustainable status quo may compel the US to agree to a limited deal (20%, up from 10%), though talks are currently making little progress.

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For more, please see Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026.

Quote of the Day

“Nobody read the story and freaked out because, frankly, nobody reads Politico in the first place. To quote the greatest President in American history — FAKE NEWS POLITICO!” - White House spokesperson Danielle Alvarez when asked about reports that President Trump lashed out at aides for leaking information about a potential move to replace White House Chief of Staff Susie Wiles. The reports about Wiles come amidst a series of personnel moves in the Trump administration, including the dismissal of Special Envoy for Global Partnerships Paolo Zampolli—sparked by negative reporting about him in Politico yesterday—and Kristi Noem’s move out of the Special Envoy for the Shield of the Americas role.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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